

TWO TRIPS

a short film

Blue Sheep Films

working draft v1.1

INT. CARGO VAN - MORNING

A work van, borrowed. Fast food fossils in the door pocket that aren't his. ELI (26) drives with one hand and holds two coffees in a tray with the other, like a man who has not thought about the second coffee at all.

He has thought about the second coffee since Tuesday.

The radio is on, low. Some song. He turns it off. Then back on, lower.

MAIN TITLE: TWO TRIPS

EXT. NIA'S BUILDING - MORNING

A three-storey walk-up with boxes already staged on the stoop like sandbags before a flood. NIA (26) sits on the biggest one, hair up, dressed for labour.

The van pulls up. Eli gets out. They look at each other across a distance that used to be zero.

NIA
You didn't have to.

ELI
You need a van. I have a van.

NIA
You borrowed a van.

ELI
I have access to a van.

He hands her the coffee. She takes it without asking what it is. She knows what it is. That's the whole problem with today.

NIA (CONT'D)
Elevator's broken.

ELI
Course it is.

INT. NIA'S APARTMENT - MORNING

Third floor. Half a life in boxes. The other half still on walls and shelves, waiting its turn to stop being hers.

Eli stops in the doorway. He hasn't been here in eight months, and the apartment doesn't know that. It looks at him like nothing happened.

On the nearest box, in her handwriting: KITCHEN — HIS. The box is old. The label is older.

ELI
You reused the boxes.

NIA
They're good boxes.

ELI
This one still says "his."

NIA
(not looking up)
It's crossed out.

It is. Once, thinly, in a different pen. Under the cross-out it still says what it says. That's how the whole day is going to go.

By the window: the dent in the wall, fist-height, plastered badly and never painted. They both see him see it.

NIA (CONT'D)
The dent's staying.

ELI
It's a good dent.

NIA
It's load-bearing.

They almost laugh. Both of them ration it.

INT. NIA'S APARTMENT - LATER

The dividing. Two piles have formed without either of them declaring it.

She holds up the good pan. THE good pan.

NIA
It's yours. You bought it.

ELI
You seasoned it.

NIA
You can't ship cast iron, Eli, it's nine dollars a kilo.

ELI
Then it's not sentiment, it's freight math.

NIA
Everything today is freight math.

She puts the pan in his pile like she's laying down a card she wanted to keep.

On the windowsill: a POTHOS in a chipped pot, huge, absurd, thriving. Two years of growth wrapped twice around a curtain rod like it's staying no matter what the humans decide.

They both look at it. Neither says anything. Not yet.

INT. STAIRWELL - DAY

The couch. Their couch – bought secondhand, carried up these same stairs two years ago by two people who thought stairs were funny.

Now: three floors of switchbacks, a couch, and two people being extremely careful with their pronouns.

ELI
(backing down, blind)
Left. Your left. My– yeah.

NIA
Don't say pivot.

ELI
I wasn't going to say pivot.

NIA
You were loading it up.

They wedge at the second-floor turn. Stuck. Both breathing. Her face is two feet from his over the armrest, closer than they've been since March.

ELI
We got it up.

NIA
We were different people.

Beat. She means it lightly. It doesn't land lightly. Somewhere above, a neighbour's door closes, polite about it.

They lift on three.

EXT. NIA'S BUILDING - DAY

The van, packed floor to ceiling – and a third of the boxes still on the stoop. Eli stands back, does the math with his hands on his hips.

ELI
Two trips.

NIA
You said one.

ELI
I said one if the couch behaved.

Nia looks at the boxes. At the van. At the day getting longer in both directions.

NIA
Two trips.

Neither of them sounds upset about it. That's the part neither of them examines.

INT. CARGO VAN - MOVING - DAY

Trip one. The city sliding by. She rides shotgun with the window cracked, and – without thinking – puts her feet up on the dash. The exact way. The whole history of them is in the angle of her ankles.

She catches herself doing it. Puts her feet down, one at a time, quietly, like leaving a room where someone's sleeping.

Eli watches the road with tremendous discipline.

The radio plays, low. Neither of them touches the dial the entire drive. Changing it would mean admitting the last one was a song.

INT. FREIGHT DEPOT - DAY

A warehouse of other people's lives on pallets. Shrink wrap. Barcodes. A DEPOT GUY (40s) with a scanner gun and the serenity of a man who moves a hundred households a week.

The couch goes onto a pallet. A forklift takes it up and away, their couch, airborne, rotating slightly, absolutely indifferent.

DEPOT GUY
Destination?

NIA
Vancouver.

DEPOT GUY
(scanning)
Nice out there. Everyone says.

NIA
Everyone says.

Eli watches the couch land on a steel shelf between a stranger's mattress and a stranger's piano. Filed.

INT. NIA'S APARTMENT - EVENING

Between trips. The apartment nearly empty now, bigger than it's ever been, their voices suddenly having an echo they never had.

A pizza box on the bare floor. They sit against opposite walls, legs out, eating on paper towel because the plates are in the van.

NIA
First night here we did exactly this.

ELI
Same wall, even.

NIA
You had that terrible beard.

ELI
The beard was load-bearing.

She laughs – the real one, the one from before, up from the stomach. It gets away from her for a second and then she reels it back in and puts it somewhere.

Silence. The good kind, then the other kind.

NIA
We're fine, right?

ELI
We're fine.

A car passes outside and the headlights cross the ceiling the way they always did, and both of them watch it go like it's the last showing.

NIA
Thursday. The flight's at seven.

ELI
I know.

NIA
You know.

He knows. He's known since the day she told him, standing right about there, back when the room had furniture to absorb it.

INT. NIA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Last sweep. Nia checks empty closets. Eli stands at the window with the pothos.

ELI
You're not taking the plant.

NIA
Can't. It won't clear customs
nothing – it won't survive the
hold.

ELI
So it –

NIA
It likes your window. The old
apartment. It grew there.

Beat.

ELI
I don't have the old apartment
anymore, Nia.

NIA
(quiet)
Then it'll like your new window.
It's not picky. It's a pothos.

She untangles it from the curtain rod, two years of it, careful with every leaf, and hands it over like the one piece of evidence she's not willing to shred.

He takes it with both hands.

INT. CARGO VAN - MOVING - NIGHT

Trip two. The last boxes. The plant rides belted into the middle seat between them like a kid from a previous marriage.

Ahead: the highway on-ramp, the fast way to the depot.

Eli doesn't take it.

He just – doesn't. Drives past. Takes the long way, the surface streets, the route that goes by the taco place and the bad bar and the park with the hill.

Nia sees it happen. Looks at the missed ramp going by. Says nothing. Rolls her window down two inches and lets the city come in – kitchens, someone's TV, summer leaving.

The long way takes twenty minutes more. Both of them let it.

INT. FREIGHT DEPOT - NIGHT

The last boxes on the last pallet. The Depot Guy holds out the scanner's little screen.

DEPOT GUY

Sign here.

Nia signs. Two years palletized, shrink-wrapped, barcoded. The forklift takes it up into the shelving and somewhere in the racks it stops mattering which pallet is hers.

The Depot Guy wanders off. And then it's just the two of them in a warehouse aisle with nothing left to carry.

NIA

So.

ELI

So.

NIA

Thank you for the van.

ELI

It's not my van.

NIA

Thank you anyway.

The hug happens. It starts as the short kind. It doesn't stay the short kind. Her hand closes on the back of his jacket, one fistful, and lets go before it means anything –

– after it means everything.

She steps back. Puts the depot pen in her pocket. Notices. Doesn't give it back. He notices her notice. Neither of them says the thing.

NIA (CONT'D)

Drive safe.

She walks toward the exit sign like someone who has practised walking toward exit signs, and does not turn around, because she knows exactly what turning around does.

INT. CARGO VAN - NIGHT

Eli in the driver's seat. The engine off. The parking lot sodium-orange through the windshield.

Behind him: an empty van. Furniture blankets folded in the corner. Ratchet straps coiled. Nothing left to hold down.

Beside him: the pothos in the middle seat, belted, leaves moving slightly in the air from the vents.

It's the fullest the van has been all day.

He starts the engine. Reaches for the radio. Stops.

Leaves it off, and drives.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END